Introduction to Academic Writing

Academic writing is a specific type of writing that uses formal language and structure. It focuses on presenting information and research in a clear and concise manner.

Sentence Structure

Sentences in academic writing should be grammatically correct and well-constructed. They should be complete thoughts and follow a clear subject-verb-object structure.

1 Active Voice

The subject of the sentence performs the action.

2 Passive Voice

The action is performed on the subject.

3 Conciseness

Avoid unnecessary words and phrases.

Paragraph Structure

Paragraphs in academic writing should be organized and logical.
Each paragraph should focus on a single idea and have a clear topic sentence.

1. **Topic Sentence**

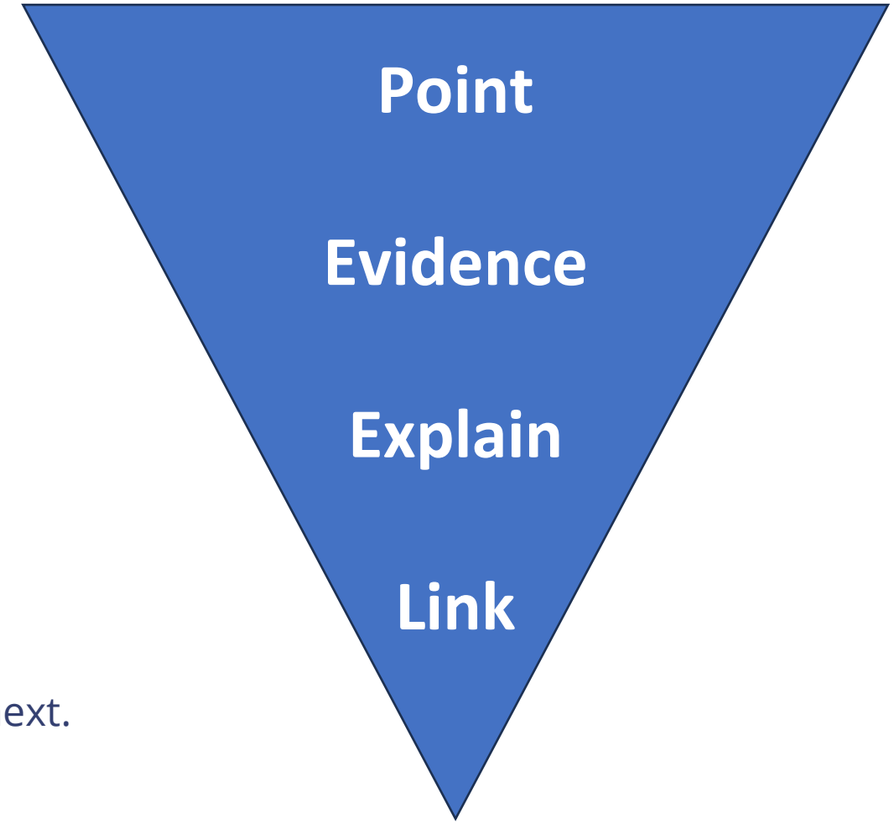
   The main idea of the paragraph, often the first sentence.

2. **Supporting Sentences**

   Provide evidence and elaboration to support the topic sentence.

3. **Concluding Sentence**

   Summarizes the main point of the paragraph and transitions to the next.



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Verb Tense Consistency

Maintaining consistent verb tense throughout your writing is essential for clarity and accuracy. Use the tense that best suits the context of your writing.

1

Present Tense

Describes actions happening now.

2

Past Tense

Describes actions that happened in the past.

3

Future Tense

Describes actions that will happen in the future.

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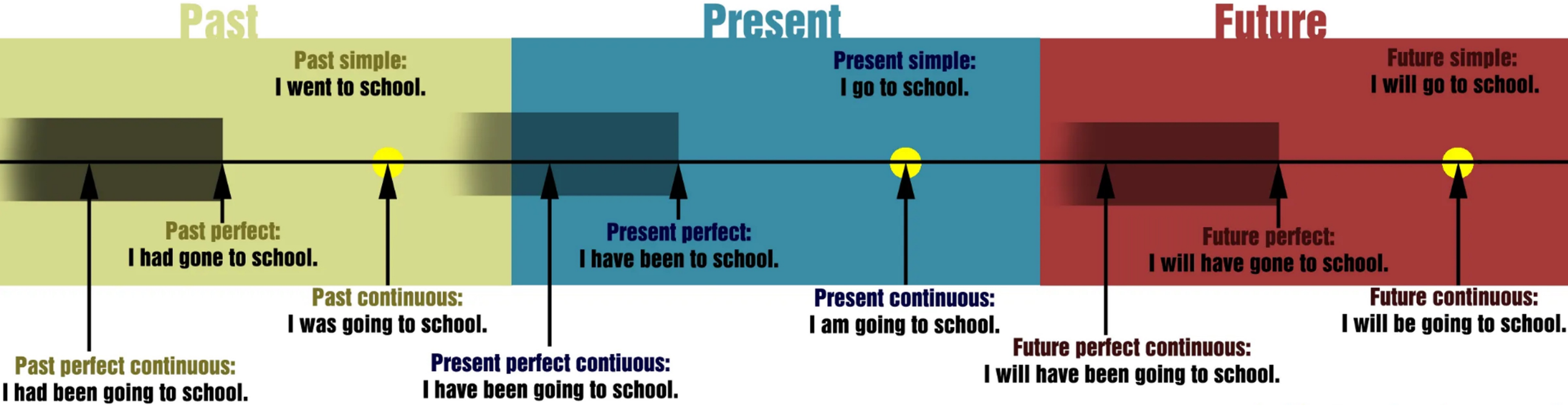

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Subject-Verb Agreement

Subjects and verbs must agree in number (singular or plural). This means a singular subject takes a singular verb, and a plural subject takes a plural verb.

Singular Subject

The **student** writ**es** a paper.

Plural Subject

The student**s** **write** papers.

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Practice:

Underline the subject (or compound subject) and then identify the verb that agrees with it.

Example: Everyone in the telecom focus group (has/have) experienced problems with cell phones

1. Your friendship over the years and your support **(has/have)** meant a great deal to us.
2. Hamilton Family Center, a shelter for teenage runaways in San Francisco, **(offers/offer)** a wide variety of services.
3. The main source of income for Trinidad **(is/are)** oil and pitch.
4. The chances of your being promoted **(is/are)** excellent.
5. There **(was/were)** a Pokémon card stuck to the refrigerator.
6. Neither the professor nor his assistants **(was/were)** able to solve the mystery of the eerie glow in the laboratory.
7. Many hours at the driving range **(has/have)** led us to design golf balls with GPS locators in them.
8. The board of directors, ignoring the wishes of the neighbourhood, **(has/have)** voted to allow further development
9. Every year, during the midsummer festival, the smoke of village bonfires **(fills/fill)** the sky.
10. The story performers **(was/were)** surrounded by children and adults eager to see magical tales.

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Pronoun Usage

Pronouns should clearly refer to their antecedents (the nouns they replace). Pronouns should also agree in gender and number with their antecedents.

Clear Reference

Avoid ambiguous pronoun references.

Agreement

Ensure pronouns agree with their nouns in gender and number.

Specificity

Use specific pronouns instead of vague ones.

3rd 2nd

Incorrect: When a *person* goes to a restaurant, *you* should leave a tip.

3rd 3rd

Correct: When a *person* goes to a restaurant, *he or she* should leave a tip.

Do not use 1st (I, we) or 2nd (you) person pronouns

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Practice:

Which of the following sentences is correct and which is not.

- ✗ Tina and Arial went to the mall after she finished her exam.
- ✗ Tina and Arial went to the mall after she finished their exam.
- ✓ Tina and Arial went to the mall after they finished their exam.
- ✓ Tina and Arial went to the mall after Arial finished her exam.
- ✓ Tina and Arial went to the mall after Tina finished her exam.
- ✗ Tina and Arial went to the mall after they finished her exam.

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Practice:

Complete the following sentences by selecting the correct pronoun.

1. In the current economy, nobody wants to waste __their__ money on frivolous things.
2. If anybody chooses to go to medical school, __they__ must be prepared to work long hours.
3. The plumbing crew did __their__ best to repair the broken pipes before the next ice storm.
4. If someone is rude to you, try giving __them__ a smile in return.
5. My family members have __their__ mistakes, but I still love them no matter what.
6. The school of education plans to train __its__ students to be literacy tutors.
7. The commencement speaker said that each student has a responsibility toward __themselves__.
8. My mother's singing group has __its__ rehearsals on Thursday evenings.
9. Dana should not suffer __her__ pain alone.
10. I thought the flock of birds lost __its__ way in the storm.

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Avoiding Passive Voice

Passive voice often makes writing wordy and indirect. Active voice is generally preferred in academic writing because it is more direct and concise.

Passive Voice	The experiment was conducted by the researchers.
Active Voice	The researchers conducted the experiment.

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Practice:

Determine if these sentences are in the active (A) or passive voice (P).

1. The coffee was still boiling after the waiter served it. A
2. The students worked on their papers all night. A
3. The wind was making the tree sway. A
4. Her hand was held up to answer the question. P
5. The three dogs were being walked. P
6. The earth continually spins on its axis. A
7. The students were released from class. P
8. Nathaniel gave his speech flawlessly. A
9. Without interruption, the scarf was knit by Margot. P
10. We were driven to the beach by Caleb in his minivan. P
11. The class was taught by Heather in the evenings. P
12. Café Moka closed early, so Danielle brewed her own pot of coffee. A
13. The professor and her aid passed out the exam which the students took. A
14. Griff explained the importance of proofreading one's sentences. A
15. The exercise sheet was finished by you! P

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Avoiding Contractions and Colloquialisms

Academic writing requires formal language.

Formal Language

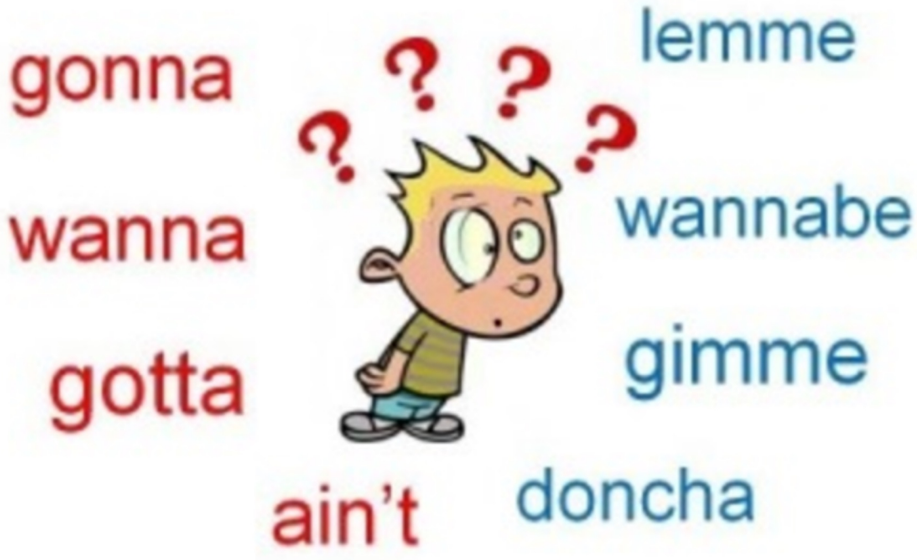
- Use proper grammar and vocabulary.

Avoid Slang

- Use standard English.
- colloquialisms (slang words or phrases) to maintain a professional tone.

Avoid Contractions

- Write out full words.
- Avoid contractions (can't, don't)



Don't	Do not
Won't	Will not
Isn't	Is not
Haven't	Have not
Can't	Cannot

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Practice:

Spot the mistakes in the following paragraph and fix them.

5G technology is revolutionizing the way we connect to the internet, and it's bringing fast speeds that allow data to be transferred more quickly than ever. It's not only improving our mobile networks, but it's also allowing for devices to connect better. These faster speeds makes it easier for people to stream, download, and communicate in real-time. With 5G, cities and businesses is now able to build smarter systems that can handle more traffic without slowing down. It's rollout happened faster than experts anticipated, and we expect 5G technology to change the way our industries operates.

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Thank you